Palace of the End - Instruments of Yearning

By Judith Thompson

INTRODUCTION

As a boy Saddam Hussein would heat an iron poker until it was white-hot, then use it to impale cats and dogs. Years later, when he had boys of his own, he would take them into prisons so they could watch — and get used to — torture and executions. The Arab world is replete with dictators, many of them ruthless. But for sheer unbridled cruelty, none of them can touch Saddam. And for hellish and sadistic brutality, no other Arab state — perhaps no other state in the world — can compare with what Saddam Hussein created in Iraq.

In this monologue, "Instruments of Yearning," we hear from Nehrjas Al Saffarh, the wife of an Iraqi dissident and leader of the Communist party. She and her sons were tortured by Saddam's secret police, and she alone lived to tell of the events.

Instruments of Yearning from The Palace of the End by Judith Thompson

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NEHRJAS: **(Pg 28-40)** *(a beautiful, but haunted Iraqi woman of about 50)* It broke our hearts that the United States land of the free, home of the brave – liberty and justice for all – was supporting Saddam through the sixties and even the seventies. After the coup, the CIA gave a list of the names of everyone in the Communist Party; they were making his army and all his torturers all powerful. We wondered, did the people of the United States know that their taxes were paying for instruments of torture? We had to be very secretive. We had to let our babies cry at night so that their cries would cover the sound of typing. If the secret Police heard typing, they would arrest us immediately. One day they took my little brother. He was a silly boy, he like to dance with girls and drink alcohol and wear expensive clothing and he was at the University. He was taken. We did not know where he was. We got a phone call in the morning. "We are sending him home in a cab." We waited all day. The cab arrived. The cab driver said in Arabic, "There is a God" – because my brother was, thank God, still alive –

We rushed him into the house because if the neighbors saw, they would shun us – they would be afraid of guilt by association. And he – he was so badly beaten, we couldn't

recognize his face. And he . . . he could see nothing. My other brother cried and my mother said, "It is alright. This is the way men learn to be men." It seems harsh, but you have to understand the way we lived, and what it was to be a man. He said that his friend talked back to them – they beat him worse, but he was still breathing. And then they buried him alive. My husband, as soon as he could, he went into hiding as he, at that time, was the great, visionary leader of the Communist party.

So, the monsters we lived in fear of were the Baath secret police, "Jihaz Haneen," if you can believe it. In English? "The Instruments of Yearning." Can you explain that to me please?

The torture jails were two fairy tale castles, from long ago, where the King had lived – we had not liked him either. He was Saudi, but he was nothing compared to Saddam. The gardens were tended by a master gardener, a true genius of nature. And so the castle was called The Palace of Flowers. Until the Dark Age, when it became the Palace of the End. "Qasr al-Nihayah." Iraq's own house of horrors; our children weren't afraid of fictional witches or monsters. Those stories are only for peaceful places; our children had nightmares about the Palace of the End.

"O, people of Iraq . . . By God, I shall strip you like bark, I shall truss you like a bundle of twigs, I shall beat you like stray camels . . . By God, what I promise, I fulfill; what I purpose, accomplish; what I measure, I cut off." So said al-Hadjadj, the newly arrived governor of Iraq in the year 694 . . . so said Saddam . . . so said George Bush . . . and here we are. So . . .

So. They began to torture my son Fahdil. They said all we want to know is where is your father. You tell us, you can have bread and water. About six hours later, he said he would tell them. I was almost relieved. But then he told them a lie. They gave him bread and water while the others went to find my husband. He whispered to my older son that the reason he told the lie was although he knew they would keep beating him, he thought that the bread and water would give him the strength to keep the secret . . . to endure more torture. And so they came back. And beat him more. I was tied up, on my back, forced to watch, as was my older son. Well, Fahdil lied three times. Three times he got bread and

water, but the third time, they were onto his trick. They were furious. Now they beat him hard, with the full strength of men. He said to my older son: "I'm dying," he said, "I feel death around me. I want you to take care of my mother and little sister." They thought . . . what more can we do? What can we do to break down this child and his mother? Meanwhile, they had taken away my older son, Nahdne, they had let him go.

What they did then? Do you notice I have no fan here in my apartment? There was a fan in the torture room. Right above me where I was tied. They grabbed little Fahdil by his shirt. He was able to look at me one last time. My precious boy, he looked into my eyes with his beautiful sorrowful eyes and he smiled. I said, "I love you, my son." He did not scream. He did not even whimper. My son was more brave than many full grown men, and he was eight years old. They turned him upside down, and then they tied him to the ceiling fan – upside down. They died him to the ceiling fan and they turned it to fast. So my son is spinning He is spinning round and round I cannot put into words the feelings inside me.

I was praying and he was praying. We were in the hands of the devil, no doubt, but we had faith that we would be delivered – faith was all we had. And neither of us will speak. IF we give in, we are giving not only our lives but the lives of millions. It would be like giving up Nelson Mandela, you understand? It would be like saying, "yes; you can go and murder these million children, to save ourselves." And I knew, I was quite certain they would not kill us because it was so deeply in my culture to never harm a pregnant woman or a child. I thought: We will survive this. My son will be known forever as the most heroic child who ever lived. He will become a great leader. But he kept spinning.

My son who loved to write stories and draw pictures of animals. Who called our black and white cat "Precious" . . . who loved geckos, gave everyone he saw a name, and you know in Iraq they are everywhere. But he had a story for each one. He always hoped to see a cheetah, for there are few cheetahs in Iraq. He would pray to Allah to see a cheetah and have a running contest, for he was a very fast runner . . . spinning upside down over my

face. And still, I did not speak. The baby was turning and turning inside my belly. I fainted many, many times that day.

After hours and hours of the spinning, my son, of course, was unconscious. And they threw him on the roof. It was cold then. It was winter. He had no coat, of course. And they carried me up to an attic room, just underneath the room and tied me down. And still I did not speak. For days and days I lay there. The only thing keeping me breathing was that I could hear my son coughing on the roof. That gave me such happiness . . . to hear him cough. I knew he was sick. He probably even had pneumonia, but the coughing meant that he was alive! And as long as he was alive, when they let us go, I could nurse him to good health again. I was sure they would try to look like good-hearted men, and at the very last minute they would let us go. I was so sure, and that is why I did not speak. Every hour was like a day, every day like a year . . . his cough was stronger and louder and then it began to get weaker . . . and weaker. Why did I not speak then? . . . . And weaker still . . . . and then he did not cough anymore. *(Long beat)*

They came in, laughing. "We found your husband anyway, you foolish woman And, oh . . . we are sorry about your son. We were going to let him go today, but he must have had a weak constitution. He is with Allah."

The Palace of the End . . .

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